

Importing cats and dogs from Middle East conflict-affected areas

If you and your pets are impacted by the Middle East conflict, please contact us for advice on your situation.

Call 1800 900 090 or email at imports@aff.gov.au

Australia's import requirements for cats and dogs from Middle Eastern countries have not changed. Cats and dogs must arrive in Australia with a valid biosecurity import permit and meet all import requirements.

Cats and dogs that do not meet Australia's import requirements pose a biosecurity risk to Australia.

Australian cats and dogs who have travelled overseas must meet strict import conditions before returning to Australia.

Find out the requirements for:

- cats and dogs in Australia being prepared for overseas travel
- cats and dogs from Australia preparing to return to Australia from overseas

Before you leave Australia

Your cat or dog will lose their Australian health status as soon as they leave Australia.

Make sure you know the rules as early as possible. This will help you plan your return.

Your export obligations

When travelling from Australia to another country with your cat or dog, you must comply with our [export requirements for live animals](#). You must also comply with conditions set by the importing country.

If your cat or dog is not prepared before you leave Australia, they will need to wait 180 days before they can return.

See more on [preparing your cat or dog for export](#).

For advice on how to export your dog or cat, contact our Exports team on:

- 1800 900 090 (within Australia)
- +61 3 8318 6700 (outside Australia)

See a [list of contacts](#) for each regional export office.

Your import obligations

Cats and dogs can only be imported into Australia directly from [approved countries](#).

You will need to know:

- what category country you are returning from
- the import conditions and pre-export preparations your pet must meet

You can find this information in our [step by step guides](#).

Your cat or dog will need to meet import conditions to return to Australia. The conditions will depend on the countries you visited while overseas.

Export health certificate

You must present your cat or dog's export health certificate, or the certificate number. This was issued to you before you left Australia.

Present the certificate, or the number, when you apply for an import permit to return to Australia.

If you no longer have this certificate or the certificate number, contact the [regional office](#) your pet was exported from, as they may be able to assist with providing a copy.

The export health certificate issued in Australia must contain your pet's microchip number. The microchip must be scanned and recorded for every test, treatment and examination required for your pet's return.

You must meet the standard requirements outlined in the relevant

[step by step guide](#).

If you are unsure about your travel plans

We recommend you prepare your cat and dog in Australia before they go overseas. This will make returning them to Australia simpler and quicker.

This may include rabies preparation, even if you do not plan to travel to Group 3 or non-approved countries.

Travel to a Group 1 country

Australian cats and dogs travelling directly between Australia and Group 1 rabies-free countries must meet the standard requirements.

Check your relevant [step by step guide](#).

Travel to a Group 2 country

Australian cats and dogs returning from a Group 2 country may be exempt from the:

- official identity declaration, or
- 180-day residency period

The exemption applies if they return directly from the same group 2 country they were exported to from Australia.

If your cat or dog travels to any country other than the country it was directly exported to from Australia, it must:

- undergo an official identity declaration in the Group 2 country of export
- spend 180-days in that country

In this case, the animal will no longer qualify as a returning Australian animal. Your animal must meet the standard Group 2 import requirements.

Your pet must still meet all other import requirements. See your relevant [step by step guide](#).

Contact imports@aff.gov.au for advice if you have travelled, or are planning on travelling, through multiple Group 2 countries.

If there is a chance your cat or dog will visit a Group 3 or non-approved country, we recommend that you protect them against rabies before leaving Australia.

This protection may allow your cat or dog to return to Australia at short notice. It will not matter what other Group 2 countries your pet visited.

See more on [rabies vaccination and testing](#).

Travel to a Group 3 or non-approved country

Cats and dogs returning to Australia from a Group 3 country may be eligible for a 10-day post entry quarantine period.

If you can present evidence of the export health certificate (or the certificate number) issued to your cat or dog before leaving Australia, you do not need to get your pet's identity verified overseas.

Your pet must still meet all other import requirements. See your relevant [step by step guide](#).

If your pet has visited a non-approved country, they must be prepared for export back to Australia in an approved country.

If you complete rabies preparation in Australia

If you are planning to take your dog or cat to a Group 3 or non-approved country and you want to be able to bring them back to Australia at short notice, you need to:

- vaccinate your pet against rabies before they leave Australia,
AND
- have a rabies neutralising antibody titre test (RNATT) done through the [Australian Centre for Disease Preparedness](#) (ACDP). The test must return an acceptable result of 0.5IU/ml or more before you leave Australia.

You must make sure your cat or dog maintains a valid rabies vaccination and a RNATT while overseas.

Vaccinations may be valid for 1-3 years depending on the product used. You must check with your vet to make sure your pet is continually protected from rabies.

RNATTs are only valid for 1 year from the date your pet's blood is drawn for the test. You must have your pet's blood re-drawn to be retested BEFORE expiration of your existing RNATT. This will provide evidence of your pet's continued protection against rabies.

If your pet is returning to Australia within 12 months of having blood drawn for the ACDP RNATT, no additional RNATTs are required while overseas.

Continue rabies preparations while overseas

You must ensure your cat or dog maintains a continuous rabies protection status while overseas in an approved country. This includes getting:

- vaccination boosters
- fresh bloods drawn to complete new RNATTs.

Maintain rabies vaccine

Your cat or dog must remain vaccinated from the moment they leave Australia up until the date of export back to Australia.

Their rabies vaccination status must remain continuously valid from the time the RNATT sample is collected in Australia up until the date of export back to Australia.

Any rabies booster vaccinations must be given on or before the booster due date.

If vaccination status lapses, even by one day, your cat or dog will be ineligible for export to Australia.

They will need to be revaccinated, have a new RNATT sample collected and tested. They must complete a 180-day residency period in an approved country before they can return to Australia.

Maintain a valid RNATT

The RNATT shows whether your pet has developed protection against rabies from the vaccination. RNATTs with an acceptable result (0.5IU/ml or more) are valid for 12 months (or 365 days) from the date the blood sample was collected.

If you intend to stay overseas for more than 12 months, you must repeat the RNATT annually to extend its validity. Blood must be collected and tested for the new RNATT prior to the expiry of the current RNATT. This will prove continuous protection against rabies.

For any RNATT undertaken outside of Australia, you must get a corresponding RNATT declaration. This must be endorsed by an official government veterinarian of an approved country. The official government veterinarian preparing your pet for export back to Australia will provide you with this declaration.

If you are residing in a non-approved country, you must travel to an approved country annually for rabies vaccination boosters. You must also get a new RNATT and RNATT declaration in an approved country annually.

If your cat or dog's RNATT lapses while overseas, the results will become invalid.

A new blood sample will need to be collected and tested. Your pet must also undertake the 180-day waiting period in an approved country before they are eligible for import to Australia.

If you do not complete rabies preparation in Australia

If you visit Group 3 or non-approved countries after you leave Australia and you did not prepare your pet against rabies, your pet will not be eligible for an earlier date of arrival back to Australia. This includes pets who only received a vaccination prior to leaving Australia but did not complete a RNATT at ACDP.

Your pet will be required to meet all standard import conditions for any animal coming to Australia from a Group 3 country. See the relevant [step by step guide](#).

You will need to complete preparations in an approved country overseas. Your cat or dog must also wait 180 days in an approved country before returning to Australia.

Get your import permit

To apply for an import permit for a cat or dog that is of Australian origin, you'll need to upload certain documents.

- For all cats and dogs
 - a copy of the health certificate (or its reference number) issued to your cat or dog before departing Australia

- For cats and dogs who have completed rabies preparations in Australia:
 - a copy of the ACDP lab report (if completed in Australia before departure)
- For cats and dogs who have maintained rabies protection while overseas:
 - a copy of any RNATT/s and RNATT Declaration/s completed overseas

We recommend that you apply for, and hold, a valid Australian import permit before leaving Australia.

See more on [how to apply for an import permit](#).

Travel for less than 45 days

Australian cats and dogs travelling overseas for less than 45 days may be exempt from some testing and treatments, and may be eligible for short-stay conditions.

When you complete your import permit application, let us know that you plan to travel for less than 45 days. We will consider whether further adjustments can be made to the import conditions for your cat or dog.

Arrange post entry quarantine

Returning Australian cats and dogs from Group 1 countries are not required to complete a post-entry quarantine period.

All cats and dogs arriving in Australia from a Group 2 or 3 country must complete a mandatory quarantine period. Your pet's quarantine details will be listed on their import permit.

Assistance dogs

Import conditions also apply to assistance dogs returning to Australia.

There are differences in the import permit application process and post-arrival arrangements.

See more about [how to bring an assistance dogs to Australia](#).

Travelling with an assistance cat

If you wish to travel with your assistance cat, please be aware we are reforming the import pathway for assistance animals to include cats.

In the interim, we can consider import permit applications for assistance cats.

Contact us for guidance on travelling with your assistance cat via email (imports@aff.gov.au).

Contact us

You can contact us if you need assistance.

Phone

- 1800 900 090 (within Australia)
- +61 3 8318 6700 (outside Australia)

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/cats-dogs/cats-dogs-returning-to-australia>